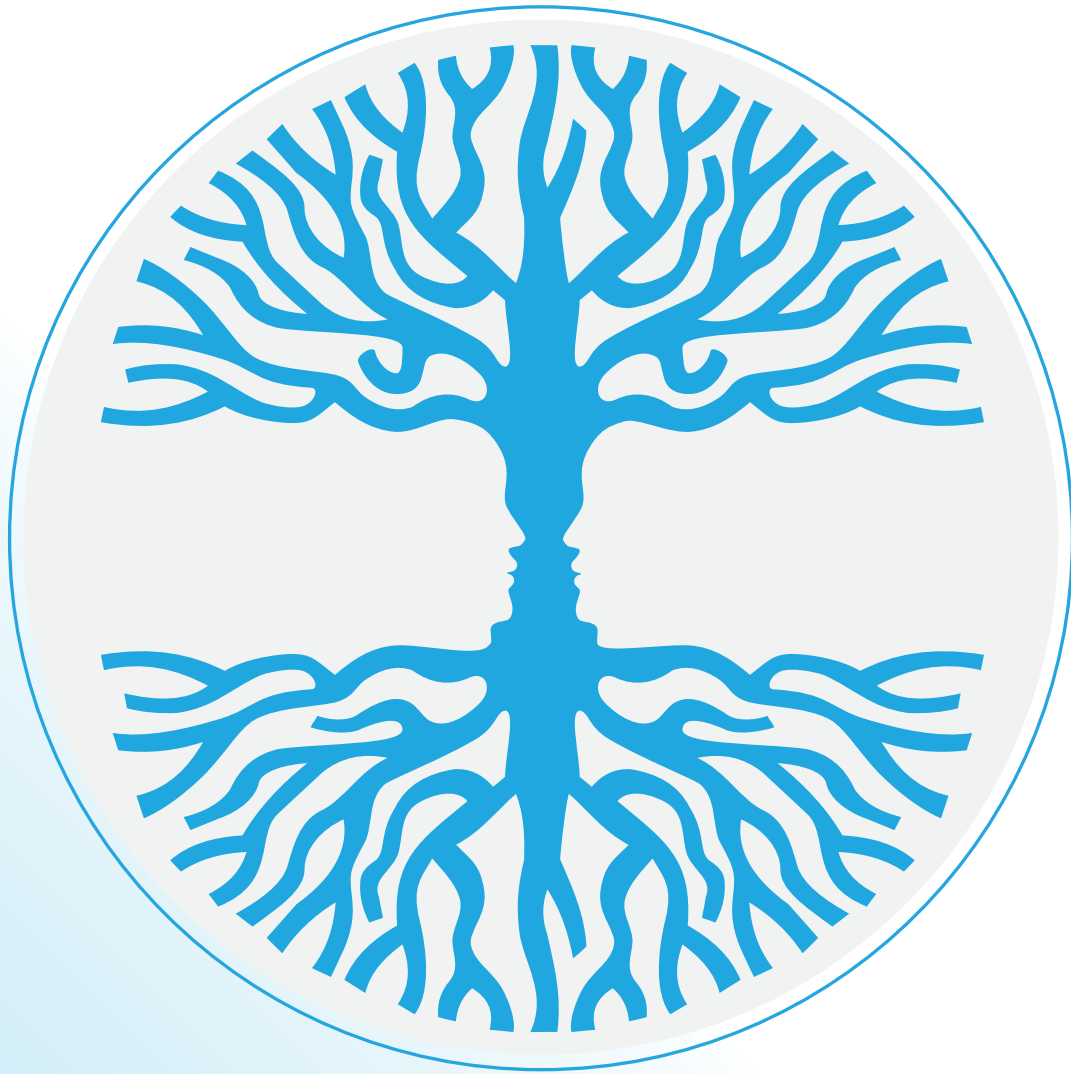


Seven keys to ace executive presentations

Master C-suite meetings with this
comprehensive, step-by-step guide





“ People generally see what they
look for and hear what they listen to. ”

Harper Lee

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Why are executive presentations important?

As a leader, your executive presentation skills are fundamental for the success of your ideas and projects. They are a vital part of your efforts to communicate with people and convey important messages. Whether bringing your senior workforce up to date on company changes or persuading them to achieve their goals with your help—executive communication can make all the difference.

An executive presentation is a concise update or proposal geared towards C-level executives within your organization. Due to the nature of the audience, these are usually “high-stake” presentations that have the potential to impact your next promotion.

Moreover, a successful executive presentation may mean that your project receives funding, or you secure the support of organizational leaders on key assignments.

70%

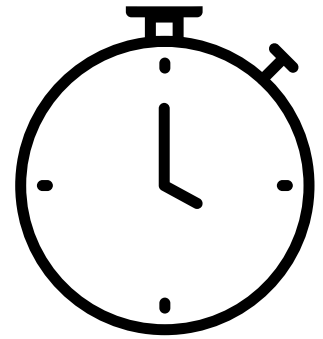
of U.S. employees
believe that business
presentations are critical
to their success at work



What makes executive presentations so challenging?

Executive presentations require professionals to create thorough, comprehensible content that leaders can understand through a brief presentation.

This can be an arduous task to accomplish, as some professionals may find it challenging to distill complex information from their specialized work into a few minutes.



Moreover, C-level executives are a tough audience. Their days are planned from start to finish with no room for error—or lateness—and, certainly, no time for what they consider a waste of time. You need to give executives a reason to stay and pay attention.

Presenting to senior executives can be challenging:



Senior executives can be impatient



They often interrupt



They may already have strong points of view

How to create presentations that engage senior executives

Here are seven keys for senior executive presentations:

Quickly frame the topic



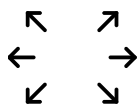
Set expectations for the meeting

Use an inductive approach



Allocate only 50% of the time for presenting

Be ready to zoom out



Customize the executive summary to the project stage

Start with a title and then build the slide





Key 1: Quickly frame the topic

In the first 30 seconds:

Explain what you will talk about and how it fits with other topics that executives have on their minds.



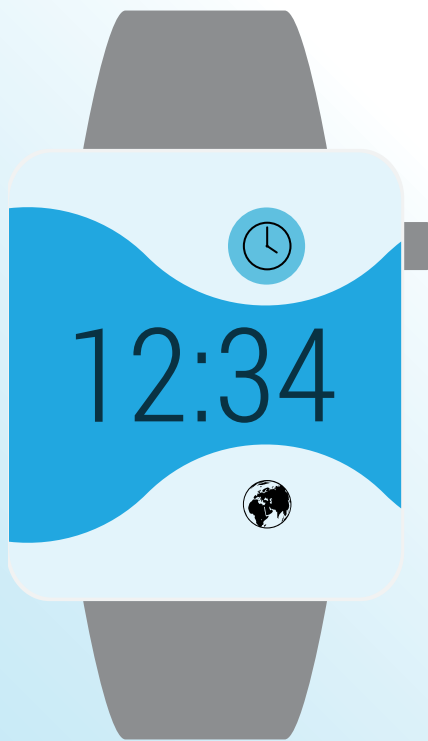
There are many topics on an executive's mind.

By quickly framing the topic, you will help the executive shift into the correct mental mindset for the conversation.



Key 2: Set expectations for the meeting

Next, you must explain how much time you'll take and what you'll cover during that time.



- **Time is valuable.** Don't surprise executives with a meeting that is longer than they expected.
- Be gracious and ask if they would like to add anything to the agenda.
- If there is another issue to discuss, tackle it first.



These small steps convey that you respect your audience's time and opinions.



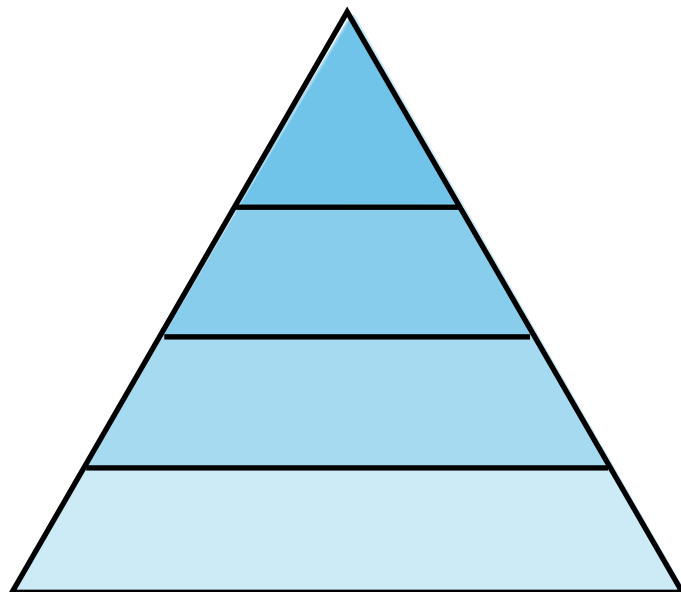
Key 3: Use an inductive approach

Start with the answer and then provide any supporting facts.

It is also important to deal with any disruptions positively and pause for questions. This helps the audience pay more attention and ensures that your presentation is successful.

This way, the executive does not have to wait for the “grand reveal.” They can ask the questions as you go along.

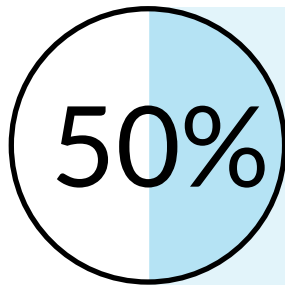
These actions further cement that you respect their time. Answering their questions will build their confidence in you and your pitch.





Key 4: Allocate 50% of the time for presenting

Allocate
only



of the meeting
time for the actual
presentation.

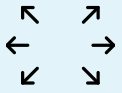
Avoid the urge to
add more content,
just because
the meeting
is important.

Treat it as a
discussion. If you have
30 minutes, prepare
content for 15 minutes.

ALWAYS save time for
questions so there's no
rush at the end. This
way, everyone has a
chance to be heard.

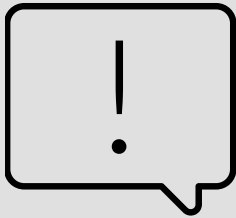
Interruptions are
inevitable and should
be expected. Plan for
them so you don't run
out of time.

Paying attention to and
answering your audience's
queries is a quick way to
win allies and supporters.



Key 5: Be ready to zoom out

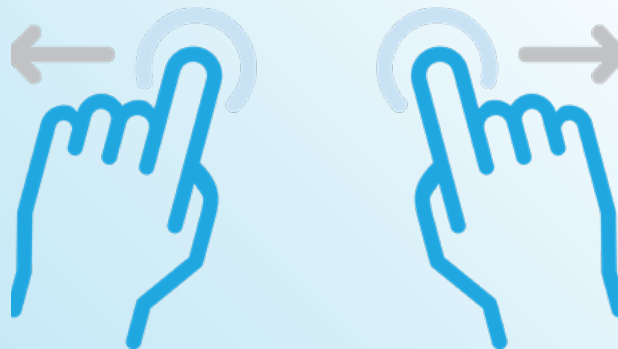
Be open to a discussion about *topics related to but not limited to* your presentation.



Don't worry if the question asked is not directly related to your topic. Executives will try to connect your presentation with other issues going on in the company.

And that's okay!

The highest impact projects require broader coordination across an organization. Addressing concerns is an excellent way to demonstrate that you always think “company first.”





Key 6: Customize the executive summary to the project stage

We recommend adapting the executive summary to these stages of the problem-solving journey.

Stage 1

At the **early stage**, an executive summary should help all stakeholders align on the core question.

Stage 2

As the problem-solving moves to the **mid-stage**, the executive summary should demonstrate progress and tee up the emerging answer.

Stage 3

Finally, in the **endgame**, the role of the executive summary changes to align the team on the conclusion and next steps.

Let's take an example of mid-stage problem-solving. The emphasis here shifts to demonstrate progress.

An “area-code” slide is a proven template to use. Here is how it works:

2

Activities



The first section has the number of activities conducted since the last presentation. It demonstrates progress made since the last check-in. This builds confidence in the execution.

5

Insights



The second section focuses on the insights gathered since the last meeting. It is the meat of the discussion. This a great way to understand dissent and other opinions early.

2

Next Steps



Finally, the last section is the next steps. It outlines the focus areas until the next check-in. This ensures there are no surprises for the next meeting.

Mid-Stage Template: Demonstrate Progress with Area Code		
2 activities 	• ... • ...	Demonstrate progress made since last check-in Build confidence in execution
5 insights 	• ... • ... • ...	Share main insights discovered Understand dissent and other opinions early
2 Next steps 	• ... • ...	Outline focus areas till the next check-in Ensure no surprises next time you meet

Mid-Stage Template: Demonstrate Progress with Area Code		ILLUSTRATIVE
2 activities 	• Created steering committee and stakeholder rhythm • Met with experts in the energy efficiency and boring vehicle design	
5 insights 	• Area required in tunneling is due to combustion engine and fumes • Area could be reduced by 3x-5x using electric skates • Most boring machines are built to rest 12 hours and work 12 hours • Continuous boring will require machines that cool • Energy efficiency of machines lower than machines used in space engineering	
2 Next steps 	• Refine area reduction hypothesis (3x-5x) with field trials • Explore possibility of machines to auto-cool (no 12-hour breaks)	

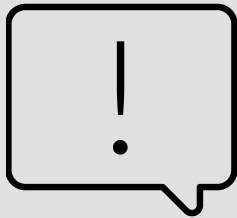
Area-code slides for reference. Source: Prezent



Key 7: Start with a title and then build the slide

Ever wonder what makes some presentations more impactful than others?

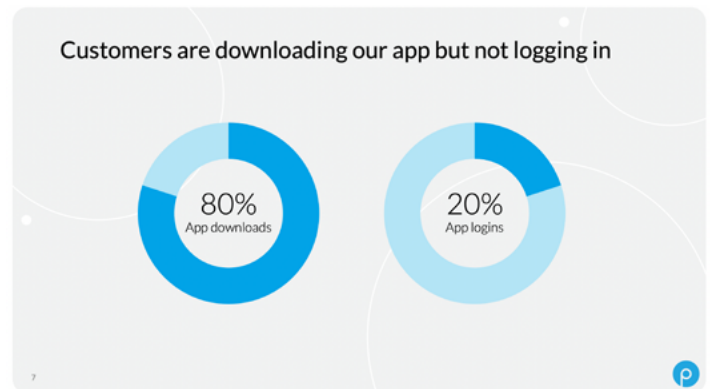
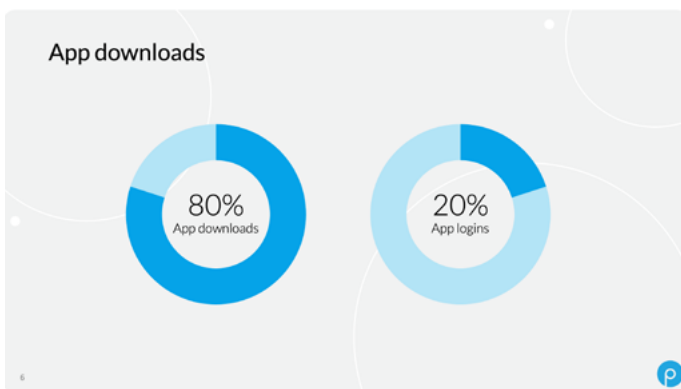
Here's the secret.



Strategy leaders follow the practice of **“Title First.”** And so can you! Lock in the titles for all of your slides before diving deeper into the content on any particular slide. Spend considerable time on each slide title to ensure it captures the true essence of the slide.

Slide titles should contain the most important idea on the slide and, at the same time, speak for themselves.

Have a look at the two slides below:



In great presentations, slide titles not only highlight the key idea behind every slide, they also flow across the deck creating an engaging storyline. This is why strategy leaders go over these titles again and again, refining them with every iteration until all of the titles come together to form a coherent story.



Try this exercise next time you create a presentation:

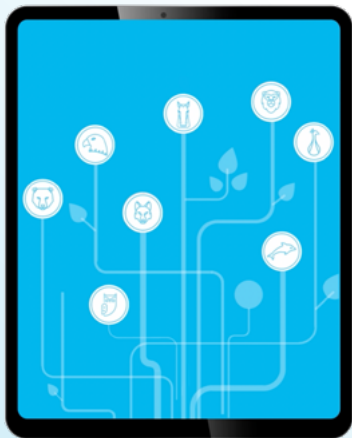
Read your headlines out loud.

- Do they include your key messages?
- Are they coherent when read together?
- Are they moving your story to a conclusion?

If not, edit or eliminate them.

How can Prezent help you build executive presentations with impact?

Trusted by the Fortune 500, busy professionals are using Prezent to save time, cut costs, and elevate their communication skills. Here's how:



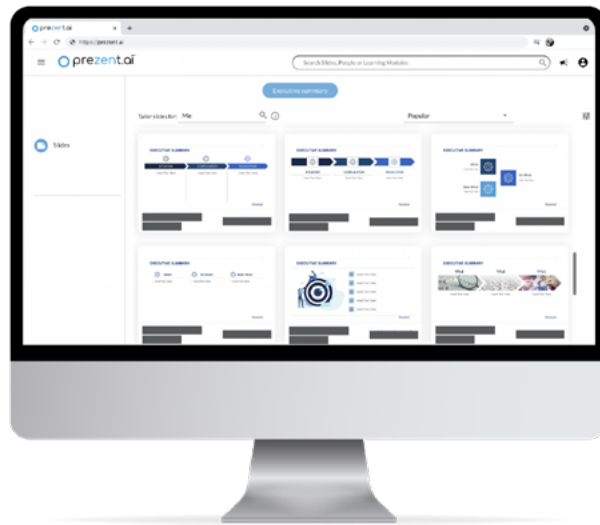
1. Know your audience

With Prezent, you can discover your audience's presentation preferences and pet peeves through Prezent's searchable database.

2. Access a library of professional slides

Prezent helps teams consistently stay on brand with over 35,000 custom-tailored slides, presentation templates, and storylines.





3. Uplevel your communication skills

Become instantly better at creating and giving presentations with Prezent's built-in curriculum.

We hope these ideas help you ace your next executive presentation! For more best practices to improve business communication, check out these resources:



Think Deeply,
Speak Simply Podcast



Prezent
Blog



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Learning Guides



The next generation of presentations.

Build better presentations faster with Prezent—the presentation productivity platform for enterprise teams. It's the only AI-integrated platform that combines audience empathy, tribal knowledge, business storytelling, and beautiful design. Professionals will stand out with well-structured, hyper-personalized, and company-branded presentations in a fraction of the time they currently spend creating presentations. With Prezent, teams can standardize content, distribute presentations instantly, and invest in team communication. For more information, please visit <https://prezent.ai>.



Try for free

Schedule a demo

